Thamesmead Times

Annual Report Special — Summer 1990

THIS ISSUE

of Thamesmead Times has been specially produced to describe Thamesmead Town's annual report. This is an exciting time for the Company; it has been turned round to profit for the first time, and the new Town Centre proposals open exciting horizons.

The full annual report is available for inspection at the Thamesmead Town office, so please come up to reception if you want to see it.

CHAIRMAN'S FAREWELL NEW MAN WITH THE WOOLWICH

Clive Thornton, after over five years' working for Thamesmead, is to stand down as Chairman of the Board of Directors of Thamesmead Town. The Directors of the Company have agreed that the next Chairman will be Alan Cumming, Executive Vice Chairman of the Woolwich Building Society.



CLIVE THORNTON

"Looking back over the stewardship of the Company, much has been achieved; the dreams of 1985 have become reality and no-one doubts Thamesmead Town is here to stay." Says Clive Thornton: "Many doubts were expressed initially about the wisdom of allowing local people to run a multi-million pound company. They should be proud of their achievement, I hope they will continue their interest in the affairs of this unique Company. I have been proud to serve this community which will always be special to me."

"I am sorry to leave at this exciting stage in the development of the Town. The new Town Centre proposals, with extensive leisure and recreational facilities, mark the start of major commercial and retail development in Thamesmead. This will provide the hub for the Town, and should secure Thamesmead's future well into the next century."

Commenting on the new Chairman's appointment, Clive Thornton says: "Alan Cumming is a chartered accountant by profession, with a vast breadth of business experience which I know he will be able to put to good use at Thamesmead."

400,000 Hear RTM Radio Thamesmead

RTM Radio has broadcast to 400,000 listeners in Bexley and Greenwich since March 1990. The franchise was won, and the new radio station was set up by, a partnership of Thamesmead Town, Community Service Volunteers and the former directors of Radio Thamesmead (when it was a cable radio, serving only 6,000 homes in Thamesmead).

UNWELCOME BENEFIT CHANGES

When the Government introduced its changes to housing benefit and income support, it did not allow private landlords the chance to get involved.

"For several years, we were able to provide a 'one-stop' service" Clive Thornton comments: "This greatly reduced the difficulties faced by both tenants and landlord."

Interestingly, several of the larger housing associations have been privately lobbying for a change in legislation to allow them to administer the schemes.

SQUEAKY CLEAN

Major changes have taken place in the way the Company maintains its residential properties. A main development has been the use of an outside contractor — Vantage Cleaning Services Ltd — to supply the routine estate cleaning services.

This employment of specialist skills, and the use of outside building contractors, have freed Thamesmead Town staff to offer first-line servicing. The response time and the quality of repairs have improved dramatically. In the early days there was a justifiably high number of complaints, lately there has been a considerable drop.

"We are by no means complacent, however." Clive Thornton says: "Service performance is constantly monitored."

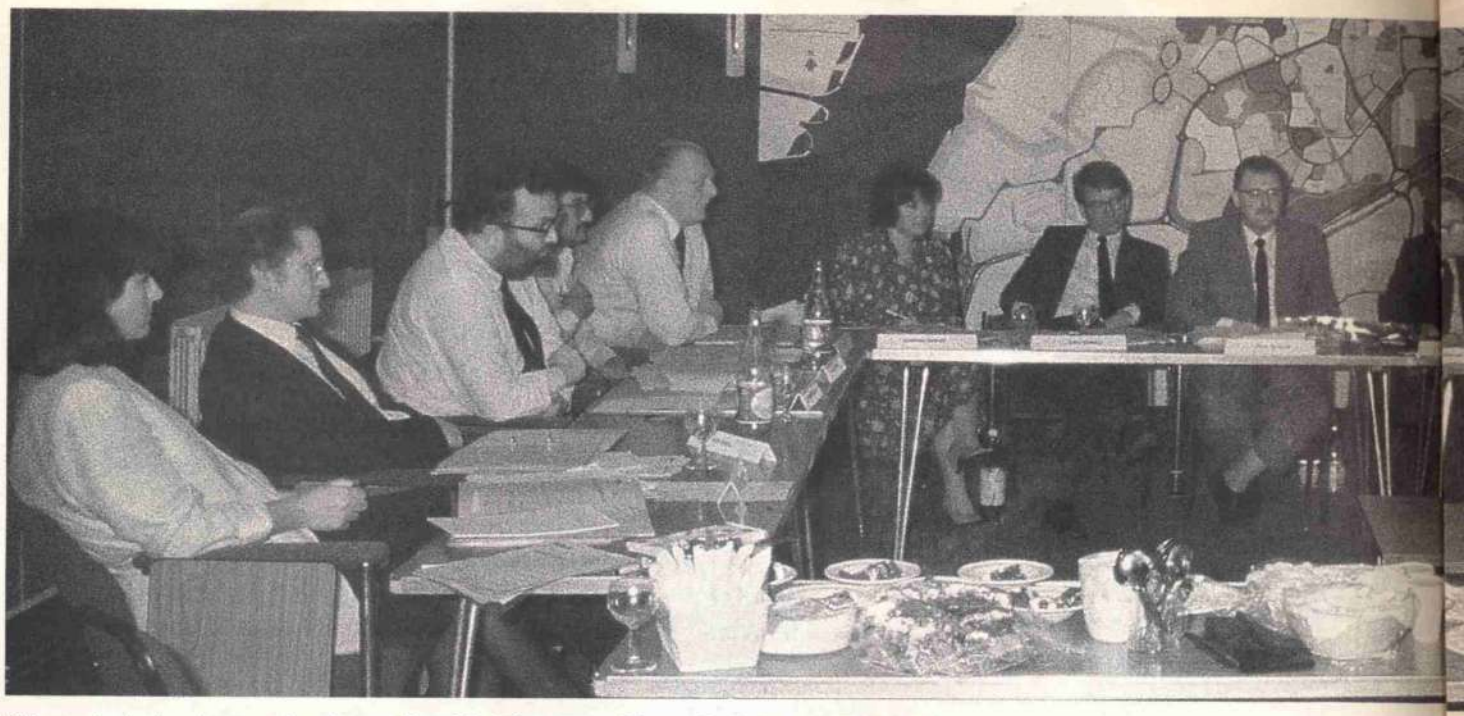
Flytipping and vandalism remain as problems. Flytipping has decreased but wanton vandalism remains. The cost of repairing it must be passed on to owners and tenant-occupiers' through rent or service charges. It is a problem that could, and should, be solved if the community were to band together.

800 Thamesmead Homes Bought

Since the introduction of the Government's 'Right to Buy' legislation, 800 homes in Thamesmead have been bought by their occupiers. This response has been a major factor in helping the Company to finance its capital development since July 1987.

"I am proud that these 800 local residents have bought their homes from the Company." Says outgoing Chairman, Clive Thornton: "It demonstrates their long-term commitment to the viability of the Town."

He points out, however, that high interest rates mean that we must expect less of these sales this year. Also, it means there are less residential homes to let. In the first year of the Company, there were 900 available. This year the figure has fallen to 300, and the Company cannot afford to replace this stock yet — although it plans to build some smaller homes quite soon.



This year's elections have produced a new Board for Thamesmead Town. Jim Adie was re-elected for Greenmead. Austin Gavin beat Stuart Cox for Southmere. Carol Foster won Moorings. Patricia Daniels was elected in the by-election for Lesnes, after Paul Beadle was disqualified in July 1989, and then successfully defended her seat again in April 1990. Terry Malone (Waterfield) succeeded Jeremy Cotton (Crossways) as Vice Chairman of the Board. Both

Thamesmead's Three-quarter Million Profit

Thamesmead Town's profit for the year, after tax was £758,000. The generation of this profit enhances the opportunities for the Company to reinvest in the Thamesmead community.

1989/90 has been a successful year, with many new schemes being completed. For the first time, the Company has gone into profit. Increased efficiency has helped the Company's figures although of course, a watchful eye still must be kept on running costs.

The Company has unique characteristics and it's committed to playing an active and responsible role in community affairs — including giving services and cash (£225,000) to community projects and helping create Radio Thamesmead as London's first local community radio station.

The Company gave £10,710 to charities and community organisations during the year, but gave nothing to any political organisation.

Saving Staff

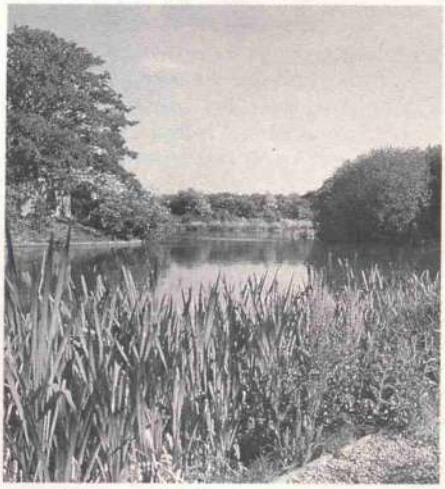
Thamesmead Town employed 296 staff in March 1990 (end of financial year), a drop from the 395 employed the last year. Thamesmead residents accounted for 29% of these and another 49% lived in Bexley or Greenwich.

A job evaluation exercise was done over that year by consultants, Hay MSL, and the results put into practice. For their help in this, and for their continuing loyalty and dedication, the Board of Directors wish to thank all the staff. The Company has completed a major reorganisation, based on new theories of a 'business area" approach, and the help of all the staff was needed (and received) to make it a success.

GREEN SCHEMES



Thamesmead Town has designed cycleways to link all the housing areas to the Town Centre, secondary schools, employment areas and major parks. It also plans to open the Thameside Walk along the whole river frontage to the Woolwich Arsenal (nearly half is already landscaped and open) and increase the total length of the canals



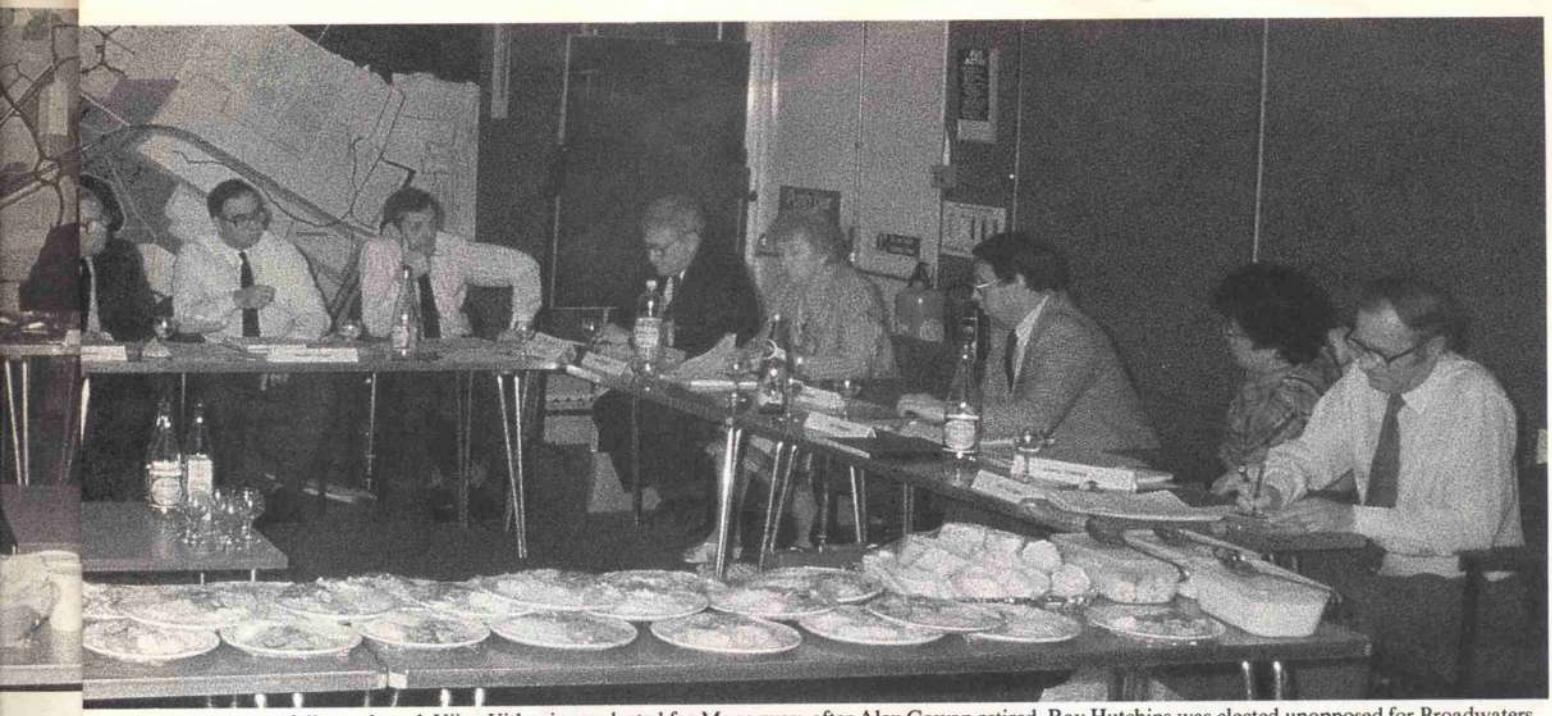
from 4,200m to 6,000m for leisure use, wildlife and drainage.

The Company has entered into another three-year agreement with the London Wildlife Trust for the Trust to manage the Tump 53 ecology area. There are proposals for an ecology centre in the pipeline and the Company is eager



to safeguard and protect the environment throughout the Town.

Thamesmead Town is a member of the London Ecology Committee. It continues its policy of operating vehicles with lead-free or diesel fuel, and banning the use of endangered tropical hardwoods.



were successfully re-elected. Vijay Vithani was elected for Manorway, after Alex Cowan retired. Ray Hutchins was elected unopposed for Broadwaters. Sam Robinson is the Director for Parkview. Clive Thornton retires as Chairman this year, after over five years's service, and Alan Cumming is to serve as the new Chairman.

Thamesmead Splits Up

A major reorganisation of Thamesmead Town took place in the last year. Management consultants, Peat Marwick McLintock, made a report about how best to manage the Town and, as a result, the whole Company has been restructured.

The management has been divided into five areas — Development, Commercial Estates, Housing, Community & Recreational Services and Home Ownership — and certain aspects of the business were offered for contract. Park maintenance, housing landscape care and estate cleaning, for example, were offered for competitive tenders.

The landscaping contract was won back by the competitive tender of Thamesmead's own staff and the estate cleaning contract winners — Vantage Cleaning Services Ltd — re-employed most of the staff Thamesmead formerly employed.

This rigorous examination of the areas of activity was aimed to achieve improved efficiency and cash savings. The fact that Thamesmead has gone into profit for the first time, and that the Town could operate with about 100 less staff, has been attributed to this reorganisation.

Cable is Coming

Thamesmead Town is involved in bringing state-of-the-art TV technology to the Town.

In a joint venture with Videotron, the Company successfully bid on 31 May 1990 for the franchise that will bring cable television to the Town. Plans to install the new cable technology are well advanced, and work is intended to start later this year.

COUNCIL'S CO-OPERATION



It's an important part of the Company's work to have good relationships with our two local councils; throughout the year, there have been regular meetings with senior council officials.

Greenwich officials have worked closely with Company staff on highway and estate roads' adoption, and much progress has been made on this important matter.

Housing has been the topic with Bexley and, again, the close co-operation is bearing fruit. The Company is most grateful for grant aid from Bexley, which has safeguarded the existence of the adventure playground in Southmere Park, and the One O'Clock Club at Glimpsing Green. This is the third year of support.

ADVISERS' TASK



TAF, last year.

The Thamesmead Advisory Forum (TAF) was allocated the sum of £5,000 to help them undertake a specific task of community work this year. It was also decided to reduce the membership from 29 to 18; nine are elected members and nine are from community organisations.

The task TAF chose was to concentrate upon 'Civic Pride'. The topic will form a major part of next year's report.

At TAFs annual Election for Moorings, Southmere and Greenmead, Mr Hathaway (Greenmead) and Mr Foster (Moorings) were re-elected unopposed. In Southmere, Mrs Strachan beat two other candidates, but was forced to resign in August owing to ill health. Iris Atkins was subsequently elected in the contested by-election.

Albert Devereux succeeded Ian Hathaway as Chairman of TAF, and Ian inherited the role of Vice-Chairman.

TAF conducts all of its business in public and gives residents the opportunity to participate and contribute to the debates, particularly where they relate to community matters. TAF met nine times last year and considered a wide range of topics, including, London City Airport planning application, development proposals, asthma, transport and a youth survey. The Forum also received presentations from various organisations including London City Airport, Community Projects Foundation, Road Safety Departments of Bexley and Greenwich, Selkent and RTM.

ON THE DRAWING BOARD

There were three major projects underway in Thamesmead during the year.

The area 7 South Loop Road was completed and opened to traffic in September, 1989. This opened up 14 acres of residential land for development and will, hopefully, allow the local bus to be re-routed through Broadwaters.

The Thamesmead Lake Edge contractr was completed on behalf of Trust Thamesmead, and over 125,000 cubic metres of Thanet sand — for future reclamation work — was imported into the development areas.

Nathan Way gravity outfall sewer contract was awarded in March, to be completed in September 1990. The facility will service sites at the eastern end of Nathan Way, and will be the first part of the link to the new, foul pumping station to be built in 1992 as a part of the Town Centre proposals.

Other civil engineering work included surfacing Harrier Mews, Goldfinch Road and Crossways. These were done on time and within budget. Design work on drainage and reclamation progressed during the year, as did plans for the Town Centre area and a new 'Licensed Tip Facility'. Talks with the statutory authorities are well advanced on all these. After fifteen years, an agreement was finally made this year with Thames Water to adopt six pumping stations and their associated rising mains. These installations provide foul drainage for almost all of Thamesmead.

Watching the Market

The lull in the property market has led the Company to prepare its plans and proposals so that it is in a good position to take advantage of the next upturn in the market. There will be less building done, with this in mind, although £4,500,000 will still be spent on development projects as the momentum on forward planning and scheme preparation is kept going.

Future Development

Forward planning is the central part of the Development Department's work throughout the year. The Company has consulted widely on several proposals to develop the Town, and wishes to improve shopping and leisure amenities for the residents. The aim is for an attractive environment with the highest possible quality of architectural design.

This year's projects have included: the latest proposals for the East London River Crossing (ELRC); London City Airport; the Jubilee Line; and, within Thamesmead, a new, urban design plan for the residential area to be built between Broadwaters and ELRC.

Town Centre Bought



Thamesmead Town bought the existing Town Centre from City Redevelopments in June 1990.

The plan is to let the remaining vacant unit and open the library soon. Part of the site was resurfaced during the summer of 1989 so that the street market could transfer and expand; it reopened in September on the new site and has since been trading on Fridays and Saturdays with about 40 stalls.

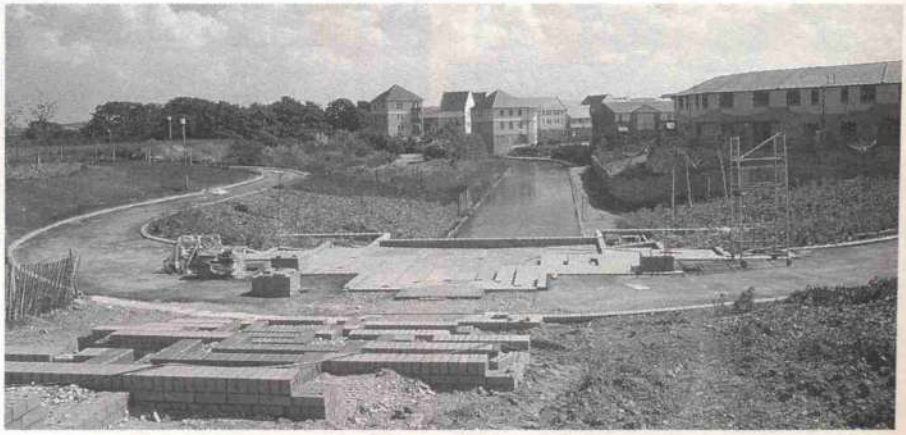
After a competition in April 1989, four imaginative plans from developers were submitted to the Company. The Board chose the tender submitted by the Heron Group which will include a large food store, a retail park and leisure facilities; outline planning application was submitted in April 1990.

Building Blocks

During this year, 143 homes were built on four sites in Thamesmead. The year before 200 homes were built, so it's easy to see the effects of the recession in the housebuilding industry.

The Company is, however, well placed to take advantage of an upturn in the housing market, when it arrives. There are 132 swellings to be completed on existing sites, over half of these are under construction now. There are also more than 500 homes, in four schemes, for which planning permission has been received.

PRIDE OF THE LANDSCAPE



Cascade Park under construction.

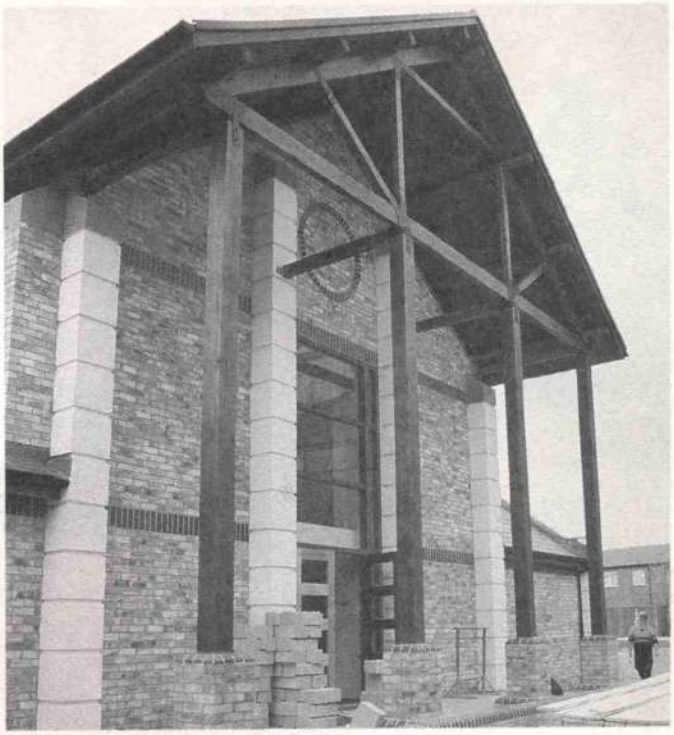
Thamesmead's Development Department is justifiably proud of its landscaping schemes. This year, the £400,000 Cascade local park, and the related Thamesside Walk in Crossness, were completed. They are now undergoing a 12 month maintenance programme before being opened to the public.

The second phase of the Crossways Lake Nature Reserve was also completed. The final phase of this development is programmes for 1992/3. Another contract completed this year was Birchmere Wood, next to the Highlands and Waterfield Gardens. The Company spent £6400,000 in total on landscaping during the year.

JUBILEE TAKE-OVER



Family outing to the Jubilee Centre



Village Hall

A federation of local community groups took over the Jubilee Centre at Lytton Strachey Path and are now responsible for its administration, with the support of the Community Team. This has resulted in much greater use of the building.

Community Teams are part of the Community and Recreational Services business section of the Thamesmead Town Company, after the recent restructure. They provide support and guidance to the voluntary groups in Thamesmead, now numbering about sixty. The support is not only given to existing organisations, help is given to people who want to set up new societies, associations or neighbourhood watch units.

The concept of federated management has been used successfully by the Broadwaters Federation at a converted shop at 3 Whinchat Road, and will be adopted for the Company's new community buildings, such as the Village Hall in Manor Close.

The Community Teams now look after all the community buildings as well. A system of monitoring and inspection has been introduced, with special regard to the community perspective. One spin-off has been the use of Thamesmead facilities for Boot Fairs. These have generated useful money for the community budget and provided a place for local groups to fundraise. Bookings extend well into the future.

BEST SWAP

The best way to arrange a move now, with the property market recession and the declining stocks of rented properties available, seems to be housing exchange. 58 exchanges took place over the last year and seven are being processed at the moment. Of these, 33 were exchanged with people outside Thamesmead. There are currently 624 tenants awaiting a transfer.

The reduction in lettings is not paralleled by a corresponding reduction in the provision of advice and guidance by lettings staff; they dealt with 850 appointments during the year, not including casual callers at the office or phone enquiries.

A new computerised lettings system was installed in April 1989. At the same time, the staff conducted a comprehensive review of all applicants to ensure completeness and accuracy of information. During the year, the Company also undertook a major review of lettings policy.

Prevention better than Cure

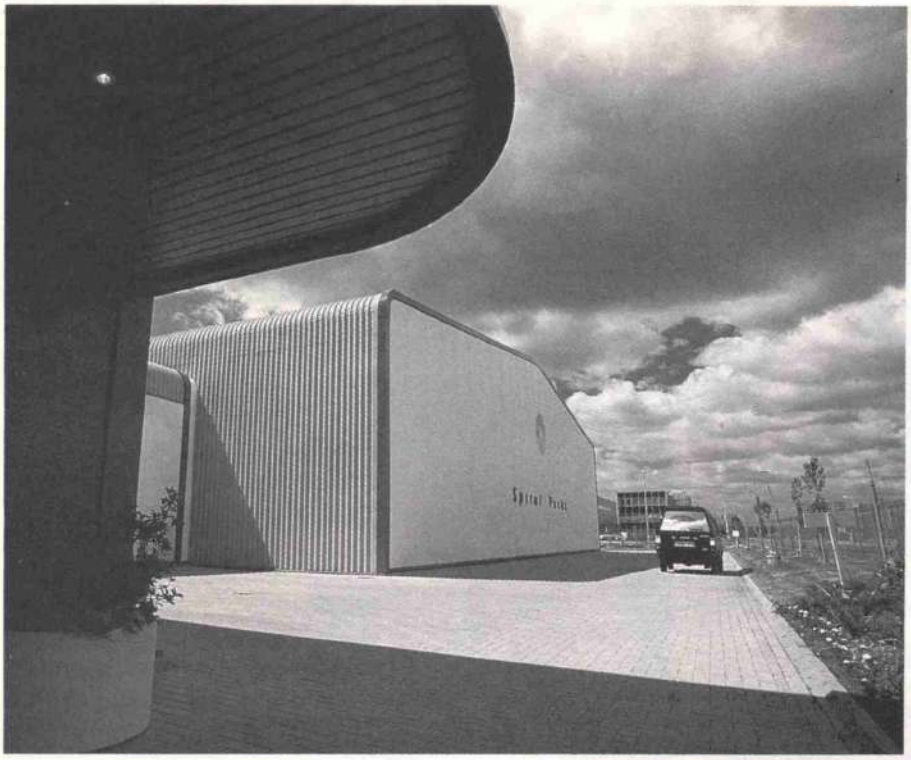
Preventative maintenance work has meant that less day-to-day repairs have to be carried out — they were down 20% on last year. Such preventative work included repair of high-rise blocks' roofs, exterior walls of linear blocks (using innovatory techniques, such as abseiling for access), window repairs or replacements and an extensive programme of external redecorations.

Multi-talented Emergency Service



The use of multi-trade operatives in the Emergency Service (and elsewhere in the Company) greatly improves the response time and flexibility of service to customers. The team has extended its skills in identifying problems and undertaking minor or first aid repairs by further training and development. The Company's emergency service continues to provide a 24 hour, 365 day a year cover for residents in difficulty.

INDUSTRIAL STRENGTH



In the first two years of existence, Thamesmead Town attracted more industrial development than the GLC did in its last ten years. This is a notable achievement. There is a healthy demand locally for light industrial units and this strengthening of the Company's industrial portfolio bodes well for the future, particularly in terms of new jobs.

21 new businesses have been brought to Thamesmead this year, together with their jobs. This has increased the Town's annual income by £395,000. Sixteen lease renewals and rent reviews have also increased the income by £31,000. Rental growth during the year ranged from 11% to 74%, with an average of 27%. Arrears dropped from £262,000 to £66,000.

The industrial and commercial property has increased over this year from £56m to £68.5m. Since Thamesmead Town bought the estate, in July 1987, it has increased by 28% every year.

The first two phases of roof renewals for the industrial units are completed, the contract for the final phase will be offered for tender soon. This has cost £345,000, so far.

The Company's portfolio now comprise 150 industrial and 46 commercial tenancies, as well as numerous miscellaneous interests.

- **Casemore Engineering bought a site.**

- **Bexley borough bought a site in Norman Road so they can build a road to the Belvedere Industrial Estate, next door.**

Electronic Keys

A trial to upgrade electronic access systems was held last autumn at Argali House.

An up-to-date electronic system was used, involving electronically programmed plastic 'proximity' fobs instead of keys. The doors and screens were also replaced with more robust, vandal-resistant materials. Subsequent monitoring showed that vandalism had reduced substantially, and the Board agreed that similar systems should be installed in a further four blocks.

Wind and Flames

The Technical Services Section has dealt with 11 house fires and the January hurricanes over the year, thankfully there was no loss of life or serious injury. The Section has been strengthened over the year to improve the recordings, planning and programming of repair work, and the supervision and administration of contracts.

RENT ARREARS DOWN

Rent arrears went down over the year, although the national trend was for a rise. At the beginning of the year, arrears totalled (620,000 (5.44% of the rent roll), by the end, this has fallen to £596,992 (4.8%).

It was necessary to use legal action extensively during the year to control the arrears position. 32 evictions took place during the year. 22 were in Bexley, 10 in Greenwich. The average debt of evicted tenants was £1,369.98.

The second phased increase towards registered fair rents took place in May 1989, although some 600 tenancies still remains below the full registered level. They, in turn, rose to the fair rent level in April 1990 in the third phased increase for the remainder of our tenants. The Company decided to defer the registration of new fair rents, thereby enabling tenants to enjoy a rent freeze for 1990.

The rent roll totalled £12.7m of which £1.6m related to fuel charges and £3m to domestic and water rates, leaving a net rental income of £8.1m. Although the Company no longer administers housing benefit on behalf of the boroughs, it is estimated that 57% of the tenants receive this benefit.

Fresh Water



The Engineering Section undertook extensive maintenance works during last summer, including replacement of water treatment and pressurisation plant at the main boiler house.

Feasibility studies into dual firing of the main boiler plant (district heating system) and the possibilities of combined heat and power generation were completed, and the first one given approval by the Board to be done in 1990.

Right to Buy

The Company limited its activities in the Home Ownership area to those properties in the Right To Buy scheme, previously operated by the GLC and the LRB, because of the downturn in the residential property market.

196 properties were sold during the year for £5,181,000 (average property price: £26,500). The company, having taken over the Right to Buy scheme, has promised to safeguard the rights former tenants of the GLC and LRB had to a discount, if they wanted to purchase their homes. The average discount was 48%. Sales under this programme fell from the 1988/9 number of 331.

This area of activity is linked to the fortunes of the property market, the Company is preparing plans for the provision of services to this sector when the market recovers. The level of sales was, in fact, better than that achieved by private developers.

● A review of service charges (including heating and hot water) was carried out this year. The estimated charges invoiced had not been changed since the Company began, despite inflation. It will be necessary to revise these, this year.

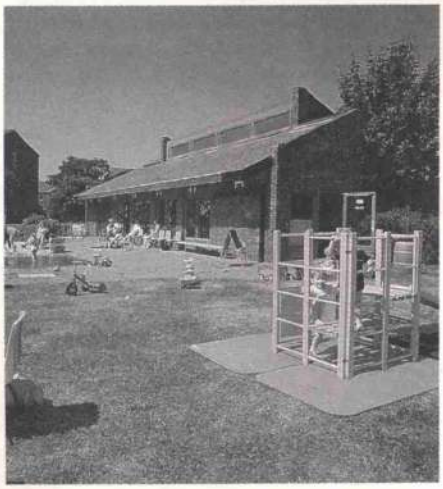
NO SAIL ON SOUTHMERE



Boating has not been possible most of the year at Southmere owing to water conditions. The search for the problem behind the abnormally high coliform bacteria levels has continued apace. It now seems likely that the source is not in Thamesmead at all, but upstream of the watercourse feeding Southmere Lake. Investigations continue. Birchmere has continued to provide sailing and canoeing.

The borders of both lakes provide a splendid habitat for wildlife and a special conservation area has been set aside, creating homes for a wide range of bird life. Rafts have been moored in Thamesmere for the many species of waterfowl that visit this lake. The London Wildlife Trust gave advice and support for these projects.

FLOURISHING CLUBS



Both One O'Clock Clubs at Glimpsing Green flourished during the year and the Company was able to divert resources so that the One O'Clock Club at Birchmere remained open.

The Playleadership Scheme provides well supported facilities for children in Thamesmead, as part of Community and Recreational Services. The Adventure Playground at Southmere Park has been radically upgraded. The Company is currently considering the future of the Birchmere facility, following two fires which heavily damaged the premises.

The Company thanks the London Borough of Bexley for supporting the Playleadership schemes at Glimpsing Green and Southmere, and a decision has been taken in principle to let Greenwich run the Birchmere club, subject to the satisfactory completion of negotiations.

Management Matters

After two public meetings with residents of Maran Way last summer, work to improve the roadway — as regards pedestrian safety and parking — should start in 1990.

Work has begun on the Moorings and, again, Maran Way to improve management and security, after a report by Hunt Thompson Associates.

Plans to tackle problems of the Tavy Bridge area will be worked up and costed by the end of 1990.

Area management teams continued in their efforts to achieve closer community involvement in solving smaller-scale problems in Town. Examples include bulb planting, garden and communal area seating and new play equipment.

Area teams made 2,000 visits this year. 40% involved counselling in rent enquiries or welfare benefit advice. 25% related to transfer or mutual exchange requests, the inspection of empty homes, or new lettings. The remainder covered a wide range for example, repair problems, neighbour disputes, vandalism, litter and garage lettings. 1,300 appointments were made for consultations at the Company's office.

2,000 TREES



Woodland renovation.

The Company planted nearly two thousand trees last year. 1,500 were poplar, birch or willow and 400 were trees not normally native to Thamesmead. 1,000 kilos of naturalised bulbs and over 300 roses were also planted.

Over 100 skips of rubbish were removed from Thamesmead parks and gardens. A new, robust litter bin design is to be introduced, it is designed to beat the vandalism experienced in the past.

LANDSCAPE WON BACK



Landscape Maintenance was the first part of the Company to be offered to outside contractors. The Company's own staff put in a tender which beat those of four private contractors, and incorporated a number of productivity improvements.

The Town's parks and open spaces are managed and maintained by Recreational Services. Its staff has gone on special training courses with Kent County Council this year, with Health and Safety training in the use of chemicals and courses on grounds maintenance for games areas and the planting of flower beds and herbaceous borders.

The depot at Southmere is being upgraded and enlarged as the main base for the new contract, and the opportunity has been taken to improve and upgrade the public toilets there — including purpose-designed facilities for the disabled. Facilities at Birchmere have been modernised and a new office built. At Crossway, the office and dressing room complex has been completely redecorated.

PHILIP GLASCOE, CHIEF EXECUTIVE, ON THE YEAR

This has been a year of sweeping changes for Thamesmead Town. Almost every area of the Company's activities has been examined and changed, for better efficiency and cost effectiveness. The Company is now a leaner, fitter organisation which has not only provided the level of services offered in previous years, but increased them.

Perhaps the most striking change is in the Company's trading position. In 1988/9, it made a loss of £1,639m. In 1989/90 its after-tax profit was £785,000. The Company is not complacent about this, we must strengthen our position because we may not be able to rely on house and land sales in future years.

For these reasons, the Company must look for efficiency and cost-effectiveness in all its services to residents. It must also look at the income it collects carefully, and cut costs wherever possible.



PHILIP GLASCOE

These, however, are matters for the future. There is no doubt that 1989/90 has been a very successful year for the Company; in fact, its most successful year.

Slippery Customer

The Company's Animal Warden does not only deal with dogs; she deals with cats and birds and was once presented with a python.

The post was confirmed at the beginning of this year, after being introduced on an experimental basis 18 months before. The Company introduced dog registration in Thamesmead which, in the first six months, resulted in over 1,000 owners registering their dogs. A number of agencies, public and private, are monitoring this innovative scheme which has meant that 75% of lost dogs in Thamesmead are speedily returned home.

TUMP 53

Tump 53 is the ecology area just off the Bentham Road. It is managed under contract by the London Wildlife Trust (LWT). The unique facility is extensively used by residents and local schools, it's also frequently visited by people from all over London. In association with Trust Thamesmead, LWT and the Company have been working for a purpose-built facility immediately next to the Tump. It is hoped work on the building will start this year.



ENTERTAINING THAMESMEAD

Thamesmead Town arranges a calendar of events every year aimed to entertain residents and non-residents alike.

This year the events will include:

- The Thamesmead Town Fayre on August Bank Holiday Monday.
- A programme of summer entertainment for children.
- A fireworks display on Bonfire Night
- The Circus and Funfair

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